

Evaluation of Competition and Travelling Diet of Elite Table Tennis Players

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ABSTRACT

Competition diet or fuelling in competition phase plays an intense role in maximising the performance of athletes. The aim of the study was to assess the travelling and competition diet of Elite Table Tennis players. The study involved 23 Elite Table Tennis Players Practicing at Sports Authority of India, National Institute of Sports, Patiala, Punjab. The primary objective was to screen and understand the diet pattern of the players in various situations. The data was collected through a small questionnaire containing both close and open-ended questions. The mean age of players was 21.5 ± 4.60 Years. The mean height and weight of the players were 166.3 ± 7.66 cms and 62.09 ± 7.57 Kgs respectively. The results indicated that 78.3 % of the players carried different kind of food stuffs while travelling which included packed food items like chocolate, biscuits, Dry fruits etc. While travelling for any International Competition only 26.1 % Players experienced Jet lag. Players were also evaluated regarding the food consumed before, during and after Competition. The dietary pattern during competition suggested that about half of the players (43.5%) relied on unhealthy snacks and chocolates. Recovery meal is important within 30- 45 min prior competition to compensate the wear and tear of muscles. Herein it was observed that only 8.7 % Players focused on recovery meal. Only 65.2% of players read the labels given on food packets, out of which only 20% players read the nutritional information. So, proper Nutrition knowledge regarding competition and travelling diet need to be imparted to the player to avoid false eating and maintaining their nutrition requirement in transit and competition phase.

Keywords: Competition Diet, Travelling Diet, Nutrition Labelling

INTRODUCTION:

One of the racquet sports enjoyed by young and old population alike in India is table tennis. Tennis is a high intensity sport involving hundreds of short bursts of activity [1]. A sportsman's nourishment must have some features in terms of calorie and quality in accordance with sport type. The aim is to meet need of

energy through carbohydrates and fats, to respond to need of protein when creating, protecting and repairing tissues and to provide necessary vitamins and minerals when carrying food nutrients in body and creating enzymes [2]. Table tennis is among sport branches requiring a quick power [2]. In this regard, sportsmen's diet

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applications must be prepared under the general nourishment criteria before, during and after both trainings and competitions.

Addition to that, Travelling has become an integral part of the players life. Eating right during Travelling before competition plays a significant role. So, the aim of the study is to evaluate the competition and Travelling diet of elite table tennis players.

MATERIALS & METHODS

The study involved 23 elite table tennis players who were practicing at Sports Authority of India, Netaji Subhas National Institute of Sports, Patiala, Punjab. The research objective was to screen the diet of the players in various situations. The data collection tool used in this research (semi structured questionnaire) consist of 3 sections. In the first section, personal information

and anthropometric details were obtained. In the second section, travelling diet related questions were given and in the third section a questionnaire for competition diet and food/supplement labelling was provided.

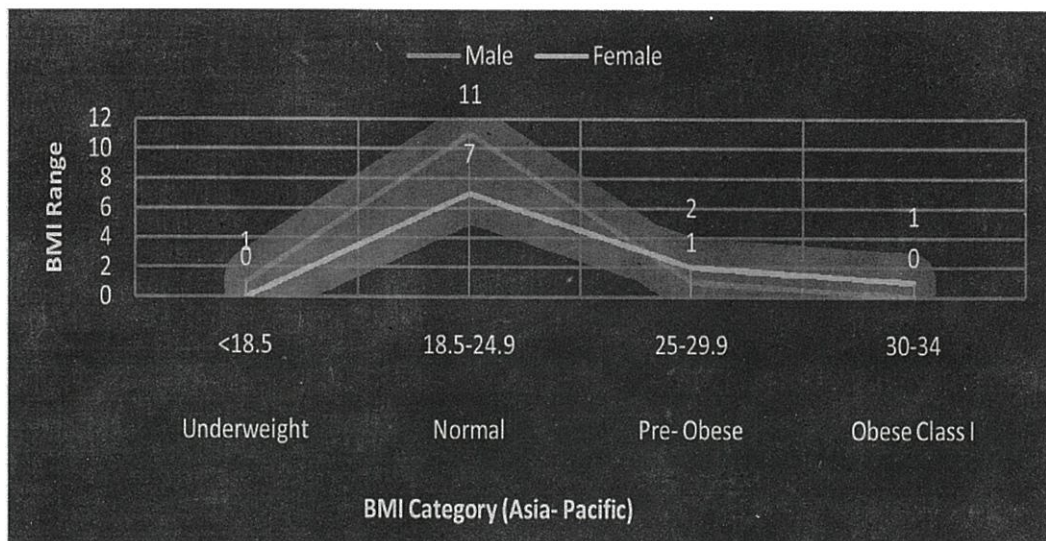
Statistical Analysis

The data recorded for various characteristics were statistically analysed. Mean, standard deviation and significant difference was calculated. Data coding and validations was also done. The collected data was analysed by formulating the frequency distribution tables. Chi square was performed to compare the practices of male and female players.

RESULTS

The mean age of players was 21.5 ± 4.60 Years. The mean height and weight of the players were 166.3 ± 7.66 cms and 62.09 ± 7.57 Kgs respectively.

FIGURE 1- BMI Classification according to gender



The FIGURE 1 depicted BMI Classification (WHO) which shows that most of the players (78%) fall under the normal weight category. Very few players fall under Underweight, Pre-Obese and Obese class I category.

The evaluation of Competition and

travelling diet of elite table tennis players revealed that more specific knowledge has to be imparted so that players will avoid false eating to maintain their nutrition requirement. Table 1 shows the various variables on which players were evaluated.

Table -1 : Dietary Practices of the players during travelling and competition

S.no	Variable	Options	Number (N=23)	Percentage
1.	Carrying food stuff	Yes	18	78.3
		No	5	21.7
2.	Experience Jet Lag	Yes	6	26.1
		No	17	73.9
3.	Food before competition	Balanced meal	18	78.3
		Fast Food	5	21.7
4.	Food During competition	Fluid+ Healthy snack	10	43.5
		Fluid+ Snack + Chocolate	10	43.5
		Meal	3	13
5.	Food After Competition	Recovery Meal	2	8.7
		Normal Diet	15	65.2
		Fast Food	6	26.1
6.	In Between Snacking	Healthy snack & Meal	10	43.5
		Combination of Healthy & Fast Food	13	56.5
7.	Labels Reading	Yes	15	65.2
		No	8	34.8
8.	Specific Labels	Manufacturing details	8	53.3
		Nutritional Information	3	20
		Both	4	26.7
9.	Consumption of water	Bottled	23	100
		Unbottled	0	0
10.	Stomach Pain During travel	Yes	7	30.4
		No	16	69.6

The results in the table 1 revealed that 78.3 % of players carried different kind of food stuffs while travelling which included packed food items like chocolate, biscuits, Dry fruits etc. While travelling for any International Competition only 26.1 % Players experience Jet lag. Players were also evaluated regarding the food consumed before, during and after Competition. The dietary pattern in during competition suggested that about half of the players (43.5%) relied on unhealthy snacks and

chocolates. Recovery meal is important within 30- 45 min prior competition to compensate the wear and tear of muscles. Herein it was observed that only 8.7 % Players focused on recovery meal. Only 65.2% of players read the labels given on food packets, out of which only 13% players read the nutritional information. All players consume bottled water during travel. Only 30.4 % Players experience stomach pain during travel.

Table -2 : Evaluation of the variables according to the gender

S.no	Variable	Options	Male n(%)	Female n(%)	Chi- Square Value
1	Food before competition	Balanced meal	9(69.2)	9(30.8)	1.433
		Fast Food	4(30.8)	1(10.0)	
2	Food During competition	Fluid+ Healthy snack	5(38.5)	5(50)	1.569
		Fluid+ Snack + Chocolate	7(53.8)	3(30)	
		Meal	1(7.7)	2(20)	
3	Food After Competition	Recovery Meal	0(0)	2(20)	4.41*
		Normal Diet	8(61.5)	7(70)	
		Fast Food	5(38.5)	1(10)	
4	In Between Snacking	Healthy snack & Meal	3(23.1)	7(70)	5.064*
		Combination of Healthy & Fast Food	10(76.9)	3(30)	
5	Labels Reading	Yes	12(92.3)	3(30)	9.67*
		No	1(7.7)	7(70)	
6	Specific Labels	Manufacturing details	7(58.3)	1(33.3)	7.417
		Nutritional Information	2(16.6)	1(33.3)	
		Both	3(25)	1(33.3)	

*Significance level $p < 0.05$

The table 2 depicts the evaluation of the variables according to the gender. The result shows that practices of consuming recovery food after competition, In between snacking and labels reading were found to be significantly different in males and females. A higher percent of males was consuming fast food after competition and for in between snacking. Practice of reading food labels was found to be poor among the female table tennis players.

DISCUSSION

In the present study we have examined the knowledge and practice regarding competition and travelling diet of table tennis players. The major findings of the study were that the practice of the players for some variables is satisfactory but for some they need to modify their practice. In Pulur & Cicioglu study (3) on food information and habits of female basketball players playing at different leagues in Ankara, 40% of the subjects showed their trainers as a resource of information about a sportsman's nourishment. The other resources were a sportsman's friends, school, book, newspaper, journal and TV, respectively. Süel et al. (4) determined that there was not a difference in food habits between elite female basketball players and male basketball players playing at 1st league. According to Yılmaz's study (5) findings about football players, he concluded that

football players involved in the study gave importance to eat regularly, they did not skip main drives and the players knew about the importance of nourishment.

In Goral's [6] and Ozturk's Study[7] it was stated that 100% (in both studies) of professional football players and 92.5%(in Göral's study) and 95% (in Öztürk's study) of amateur football players practice to consume food/meal 3-4 hours before the competition. The research by Bayrakdar et al. (8) also claimed that 88% of players suggested to have approximately 3 hours between the latest eating and the competition.

In Abood et al.'s study (9), sportsmen were randomly chosen from a female football team and female swimming team in Florida, their food information levels were measured, and then sportsmen's food levels were regarded to be unsatisfying. Sportsmen's food information was only training-targeted. Süel et al. (10) studied that basketball players were not so informed about eating healthy.

There is lack of Indian studies specifically on the travelling and competition diet focusing the knowledge and practice of the players. Further, more studies on the detailed habits on knowledge and practice would be focused to optimise the performance and prevention from illnesses during travelling and competition.

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